

Passages - Orbital

She wrote in a cramped hand on the back of the postcard a precis of everything their teacher had said, which he'd entirely forgotten but which she'd remembered with a lucidity that didn't surprise him, because she was the sharpest and most lucid human he'd met.

The earth, from here, is like heaven. It flows with colour. A burst of hopeful colour. When we're on that planet we look up and think heaven is elsewhere, but here is what the astronauts and cosmonauts sometimes think: maybe all of us born to it have already died and are in an afterlife.

Sometimes they wish for a cold stiff wind, blustery rain, autumn leaves, reddened fingers, muddy legs, a curious dog, a startled rabbit, a leaping sudden deer, a puddle in a pothole, soaked feet, a slight hill, a fellow runner, a shaft of sun.

Their vigil will end and darkness will hit them at speed.

Maybe human civilisation is like a single life - we grow out of the royalty of childhood into supreme normality; we find out about our own unspecialness and in a flush of innocence we feel quite glad - if we're not special then we might not be alone.

It made their own lives feel both empty and full at once

You must never forget the price humanity pays for its moments of glory

She holds her mother while the millennia

pass, crushing her into her chest. I shouldn't have left you, she's thinking. I shall never again go away so far. The planets whip about the earth and the light is orange and the earth collides with the windblown moon, and they stay on their step. I shall never again, she says, I shall never again.